

**The Democratic “Party” Culture:**

Cultural Achievement in the Kennedy Administration and the Rise of Celebrity

Surrogacy in the 2024 Presidential Campaign

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## ABSTRACT

In 2024, the Harris-Walz Presidential campaign had celebrities, stars, and influencers all with a helping hand on the campaign in an effort to secure the presidency. Especially in battleground states, movie stars, singers and influential speakers were attending rallies, small events and even just walking around in order to attempt to sway voters and get out the vote. The increase of celebrity attendance in the last few elections has drawn the question of when and how did celebrities become involved in, and influential in campaigns. This thesis employs a historical review of John F. Kennedy's support for excellence in the arts and culture, examining both his policy decisions and public rhetoric, alongside a review of existing literature on celebrity endorsement, political persuasion, and social media influence, and an original interview with a 2024 Harris-Walz campaign staffer. The results draw a connection through meaning transfer — the process by which cultural meaning accumulates in a celebrity over their public life and transfers to an endorsed candidate — applied across a sixty year span from Kennedy to Harris. The findings suggest that Kennedy's ascription of national importance to the arts created the conditions under which meaning transfer became politically viable — allowing celebrities to carry genuine weight in political campaigns when deployed with the right congruence between their meaning and the candidate they support.

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NOTE: “JFK” and “Kennedy” and “John” will be used interchangeably in reference to John Fitzgerald Kennedy. Any other person with the surname Kennedy will be addressed distinctly.

## **Introduction**

In 2024, Penn alum John Legend arrived on Penn’s campus alongside Chrissy Teigen and Jack Schlossberg to campaign for the Harris-Walz ticket. This was not a standalone incident. Across battleground states and college campuses, different celebrities, including Lin-Manuel Miranda, whom I had the pleasure of speaking with, appeared at demographic-targeted events to speak on behalf of the Harris campaign. These figures “surrogates” as they are called, standing in for, and campaigning for the candidate. The 2024 campaign had an increase of celebrity involvement, an increase that was dedicated to using not just their fame and attention, but their meaning and value in American culture to these candidates. Celebrities have the ability to bring their public association, credibility, audiences, and cultural value and allow campaigns to borrow that meaning, and have it be applied to a campaign through endorsement and a process called meaning transfer.

Celebrity endorsements and surrogacy, or any involvement in campaigns is not new. Far and few between before the 1960s there was some involvement by way of endorsements by popular music artists in the time. In the 1960s, Kennedy's presidential campaign changed the way the democratic party, and all campaigns ran after his. Kennedy involved new media, forms of advertisements and involved celebrities and artists all the way until his inauguration.

Once Kennedy was elected, he set a new national precedent: That the arts are important, and of national interest. This was something he did as a political strategy both for domestic persuasion as well as for the international interests of the United States during the Cold War. Kennedy elevated the excellence in arts and culture federal interest, and gave those excellent

artists a political meaning, a value that was associated with the American presidency. Celebrities now hold that same value that was given to them by JFK (and continued with LBJ's National Endowment for the Arts).

This connection is best understood through meaning transfer, the process by which cultural meaning moves from society to a public figure, from that figure to a candidate or campaign, and then to the audience. In marketing, this idea is usually used to explain celebrity endorsements of products. In politics, it helps explain why campaigns use celebrities as more than attention-grabbing guests. A celebrity brings a set of public associations: seriousness, glamour, youth, generosity, rebellion, patriotism, humor, or trust (or anything else a celebrity may carry with them). When that celebrity campaigns for a candidate, the campaign is not only borrowing their audience. It is also trying to borrow what they mean.

This thesis explores how that logic developed through Kennedy's campaign, his administration's attention to arts and culture, the creation of the Camelot myth, and the eventual rise of celebrity surrogacy in modern Democratic campaigns. It then turns to the literature on celebrity endorsements, political persuasion, and social media before examining the 2024 Harris-Walz campaign.

## **Kennedy**

### ***Before the Presidency – Massachusetts***

Kennedy's first venture into politics was at the urging of his father, following the death of his brother, Joseph P. Kennedy in August of 1944. Before John, Joe was the Kennedy who had political ambitions, and hoped to live a life in politics eventually running for President. He had been asked following Joe's death but didn't make a move for a vacant seat in his district (O'Donnell et al., 1972, pg.43). Kennedy, instead, tried journalism in San Francisco and

Germany. His real inspiration came from his time corresponding, watching, and reporting on postwar political leaders. Realizing that going into politics would be able to prevent a war more than being a political writer (and a good one at that, Kennedy had written a 140 page thesis turned published book about the appeasement of Nazi Germany by the United Kingdom) or a history teacher (O'Donnell et al., 1972, pg.47) . Two strokes of luck awarded JFK his chance to run, the first, the first, being born to the already political family of Joseph P. Kennedy Sr., the U.S. ambassador to England, and the second a seat being opened up for the House of Representatives, which so happened to be the seat of his grandfather, Patrick Joseph Kennedy (otherwise, known as P.J. Kennedy) had held sixty years prior (O'Donnell et al., 1972, pg. 48). The man giving up the seat, James Micheal Curley, was one of the few politicians who believed in him (O'Donnell et al., 1972, pg.50).

In Kennedy's aforementioned book, the editor of *Time and Life* had made a statement that fueled his slogan “ The New Generation offers a Leader – John F. Kennedy” from the foreword states “ If John Kennedy is characteristic of the generation,-- and I believe he is-- many of us would be happy to have the destinies of the republic handed over to his generation at one” (Kennedy, 1940).

Kennedy's campaign started long before, two months to be exact his office announcement. He met with recently discharged veterans and gold star mothers - noted by his peers David Powers and Kenneth O'Donnell that this started his restrained, unpretentious manner of campaigning. His brief speech in that room had all of the women in the room crowd and talking to him (O'Donnell et al., 1972, p.54). Simpler responses were seen in other instances, speaking at a St. Patrick's day parade, Boston author Francis Russell spoke to the fact that many people came to see Jack *as* their son. He continued to make an effort to avoid following old

campaign methods(O'Donnell et al., 1972, p.60). Kennedy was elected to that seat, starting on this path to be a man of the new generation, trying to do it a new way.

### ***Kennedy Responded to the Camera – the 1960 Election***

The 1960 election was a seminal turnaround for the Democratic party, the first since the Great Depression, FDR's 1932 landslide and democratic stronghold until the post-WW2 Roosevelt third term (and a year of Truman) intellectual Dwight Eisenhower, came into power. The youthful, charismatic junior senator from Massachusetts runs a novel campaign, the youngest, the first catholic and the first to use television – famously or infamously– to campaign in this new frontier, Kennedy truly ran the first modern campaign. Kennedy had understood the importance of investment in TV and popular culture (Gonyea, 2013). He had cameras and documentary, an addition to his youthful mystic, shooting *Primary* (a massive accidental campaign tool, and tent pole of the Cinéma vérité movement) a TV documentary premiering on Lifetime and RKO giving watchers the up-closer, personal view of Kennedy's and Humphrey's primary campaign in Wisconsin (Axmaker, 2015) While it is a sidebar, it's interesting and notable how the birth of a film movement was bred in JFK's campaign. Operating under the fairness doctrine, the Director Robert Drew made an effort to capture truth and objective equivalent viewpoints (MOMA, 2019). Even with equal screen time, JFK's charm and progressiveness, especially in comparison to Humphrey's more formal, traditional mannerism, contributed to a similar parasocial relationship we know of today, and is the backbone and goal of the modern day celebrity (MOMA, 2019).

The first live TV debate, heralded as one of JFK's most important factors in his campaign, is touted as a first step in campaigns understanding their new audience. Wearing clothes that stood out from the background, opposed to Nixon's grey suit on a grey background.

Nixon spoke to his candidate, and Kennedy spoke to the camera, the audience, to the people. Furthering this connection to the viewer (Gonyea, 2013). Kennedy was “made for television”, the end of the debate seeing him lacking in the poles, made up by the time the debate was over (Davis, 2016). It's reported that people don't recall what was said, (same as link above) but putting it not so nicely Richard Daley reportedly said, “My God they’ve embalmed him before he even died.” (Davis, 2016). The debate was largely visual in this new media, which Kennedy figured to champion.

JFK’s campaign really looked into, and used popular culture for the campaign through his though temporary, friendship and implied endorsement from Frank Sinatra who had written a campaign version of “High Hopes” supporting Kennedy's. Though campaign songs had been used from George Washington to William Henry Harrison, to Dwight Eisenhower, who had Irving Berlin compose his song, and was the first of the type, and “I like Ike” still holding some cultural mainstream influence, the endorsement from Irving Berlin held much less cultural celebrity capital than Sinatra did. Following this, it's been a maintained effort in campaigns to attach popular musicians and artists with campaigns and celebrities. With songs still being tied to campaigns today, like “Freedom” by Beyoncé featuring Kendrick Lamar. Campaign songs are picked with both a choice of artist, for their derived meaning. In Vice President Harris’s case her team picked a song used heavily as an anthem for 2020’s Black Lives Matter protest, from two Black, notably political artists, with a very strong fan base and from an album that has been quoted be an “a Revolutionary Work of Black Feminism”. Beyoncé is an artist both at the top of the music industry, who has excellence and celebration baked into her work (Exposito, 2020; Bale, 2016; O’Conner, 2020). Campaign songs in general nowadays are an attempt both to draw

media, fans, and attention from a given musician, but also to help a focus and meaning to the campaign, promote a campaign's values and direct people in a way to feel and eventually think.

Sinatra was a massively popular singer and used his popular song to signal his endorsement for Kennedy. Since then, several presidential hopefuls have sought to associate themselves with popular celebrities to promote their values, whether through songs that are already popular, or by way of personalized songs specially written for the campaign (Whipple, 2024).

Aside from aiding the increase of political songs, Kennedy has been the first to focus on money going to TV spots and targeted ads. Kennedy ran ads targeting specific communities, like Jacqueline doing an ad in Spanish to reach out to Hispanic voters (Gonyea, 2013). He also ran a significant attack against Nixon, featuring the current President Eisenhower slighting Nixon, which ran during the general election (Gonyea, 2013). All-in-all as presidential historian Robert Dallek – author of *An Unfinished Life: John F. Kennedy, 1917-1963* – believes that every successful presidential campaign after Kennedy had been taking inspiration from JFK's campaign (Gonyea, 2013). “No one has yet created a new template the way Kennedy did.”(Gonyea, 2013) . Kennedy built a campaign template that has been influencing politics ever since.

### ***Kennedy in Office***

Aside from his charm and attractiveness and campaign, the average 20 year old today does not remember the political markings of Mr. Kennedy. In fact In the history of the American cannon, the first thing one thinks of President Kennedy, is not the aggression into the Vietnam War, the Latin American security doctrines, or even the Bay of Pigs invasion as Chomsky

introduces him with in *Rethinking Camelot* (1993). The myth, the aforementioned tales are what the American public remembers. A man taken in his youth, a martyr for the beginning of Kennedy legacy - the husband of Jackie Onassis, the people's first prince, and the famous mistress Marilyn Monroe. People don't often recall the political choices, the monumental decisions. They remembered the legacy of fame, of excellence, the joy, and the glamorization of a political empire using intellect and artistry to pave that path. JFK's charisma, stately affairs and care to bring politics as a "party" has ushered the Democratic party into this new age. The stark contrast between the political dealings, and the collective memory highlight the focus on intellect and talent has incited the use of celebrities in campaigns, stand-ins and endorsements, using their cultural capital, their "celebrity" to transfer meaning and value from their fans, to the candidate in question.

In and around the White House, Kennedy's image, the refined intellectual with a sophisticated taste for the arts was continually displayed.

### ***Inauguration***

For artists living in the time of Kennedy, the inauguration "began everything" (Binkiewicz, 1996). Kennedy's inauguration was a milestone official step in incorporating excellence in arts and culture into America's domestic priorities. Even the inauguration gala incorporated both celebrities, artists, and musicians. According to *Vanity Fair* editor Todd Purdum: "One of the goals of this gala was to basically declare that with this new administration the arts were going to have a new and more prominent, more important role in American political life," he said. "President Kennedy was saying, 'Yeah, there's a new breeze. And we are looking at culture in our country in a different way, and it's an exciting way.'" (PBS, 2020). The

gala was held in the middle of a snowstorm with Sidney Poitier speaking, Frank Sinatra playing, and Gene Kelley performing (Cosgrove, N.D.).

In total, he had invited 196 award winning people in the arts, sciences and humanities (Halle, 1967). Around half of that number showed, and these guests signed a book and left letters at his inauguration. In receiving this book, Kennedy responded with an idea known all too well, writing “ I am hopeful that this collaboration between government and the arts will continue and prosper.” asking the organizer of the book, for any “possible contributions the national government might make to the arts in America” (J. Kennedy, personal communication, September 8, 1961).

Kennedy didn't wait till his term started to start promoting the arts and cultural excellence in the United States, inviting the attendees weeks beforehand, but a mere nine minutes into his inaugural speech, for the first time officially, as the president of the United States Kennedy sets forth his thought for his great nation “Together let us explore the stars, conquer the deserts, eradicate disease, tap the ocean depths and encourage the arts and commerce.” (Kennedy, (Kennedy, 1961). Amidst the challenges and promise of scientific development in the cold war – reaching the moon – Kennedy set aside a place for the arts among all of it.

### The Inaugural Poet

JFK's inauguration, explores this commitment to excellence and joy by his choice, and the content of the first inaugural poet. Kennedy's inauguration poem was written by Robert Frost, the four time Pulitzer winning poet, and the staple writings of rural America. JFK and Frost had a longer partnership than just the inauguration. Frost, before JFK had even announced his candidacy as a junior senator in Massachusetts, had been informally endorsed by Frost. Throughout the campaign, Frost remained a supporter, proclaiming his predication of a JFK

presidency at public events (Ott, 2020.) Frost, as an example, works well. He writes about the average American experience, using American colloquial speech and writing in approachable, everyday themes understandable to the reader. Frost, is an undeniably accomplished poet, winning four Pulitzers. Kennedy invited Frost to speak at the inauguration, with him responding yes, replying “ I can accept it for my cause – the arts, poetry, now for the first time taken into the affairs of statesmen.” (Ott, 2020.). Even before his presidency, a precedent had been set, the arts, as a stately affair, he started the solely democratic tradition of an inaugural poet. The tradition of an inaugural poet continues with Maya Angelou and Miller Williams for Bill Clintons, Elizabeth Alexander and Richard Blanco for Obama’s and Amanda Gorman for Bidens inauguration. Kennedy has originally asked Frost to deliver a new composition, but Frost declines, with Kennedy following up with a request for “The Gift Outright” - an elegy to American exceptionalism, this manner through the arts. Frost, found himself so inspired by the victory that he wrote a new poem, titled “Dedication”, a preamble to the “The Gift Outright”. The sun was in Frost's eyes during the inauguration and he read “The Gift Outright” instead.

The “Dedication”, as a preamble to “The Gift Outright” was touted to be a far too obvious addition to the much more famous poem. The poem mentions as such:

“Summoning artists to participate / In the august occasions of the state/ Seems something  
 artists ought to celebrate. / There is a call to life a little sterner / And braver for the earner,  
 learner, yearner.

Learning and yearning, a celebration of the state, and an occasion to celebrate carefully illustrates this idea of excellence and joy. Kennedy initiated the tradition of an inaugural poet,

and being supported by the most illustrious poet at the time, for being the first candidate to take arts as a matter of national interests, and of specifically presidential interest.

### ***The Whitehouse***

The Kennedy White House itself was something like a museum thanks to Jackie, a visual representation of the New Frontier Kennedy would lead America through(Farrell, 2022). While seeming to side on the contrary, Jackie was the new First Lady taking up a visible role as a homemaker rather than as a direct political asset. While John took up the role of arts and culture for America, Jackie made the presidential image a cultural phenomenon (Wills, pg. 43, 1982). Jackie, especially in contrast to previous administrations, returned the White House to its grandeur, working through historical renovations and using her love and knowledge of art and history to do so. She invited the American public to see this private and inside view of the Kennedy administration while renewing public interest in the White House (Farrell, 2022). It was truly Jackie's initiative that transformed the White House, and possibly America, into the hearth for arts that it was( Farrell, 2022). She invited artists, poets, musicians, and writers to perform and was an instrumental asset in getting the Mona Lisa loaned to the National Gallery (Farrell, 2022). Even in image, and image alone, Jackie did numbers for the elegance and modernity of the administration, aside from her long-lasting fashion influence in the States, appearing on the cover of *Look* magazine 17 times in the two years of the term(Farrell, 2022). Her image was not separate from the administration's politics; it helped make Kennedy's cultural project visible to the public(Farrell, 2022). The White House became a stage where taste, history, celebrity, and political power could all exist together.

## Amherst College Speech

On October 26, 1963, 27 days before Kennedy's assassination, JFK gave one of his last major public addresses. He speaks at the groundbreaking for the Robert Frost Library at Amherst College (Rooney, 2003). The library is named after longtime intellectual contemporary Robert Frost, his Inauguration speaker, and longtime campaign supporter, and faculty member at Amherst, who passed that January prior. Kennedy gives one of the most explicit, full scale statements about a relationship between art and national interest to the student in attendance. All his actions, all his choices and single lines in speeches coming together at this moment.

During this speech Kennedy made two important and connected arguments. The first is about national memory. He speaks to an idea that a nation is not just who it produces but who it remembers, who it honors. Frost being one of them, not a war hero, or a politician but an artist, who contributed "not to our size, but to our spirit"(Kennedy, 1963). In a similar vein his second point is that for the future of our country, and civilization, full recognition of the artist is needed. Artists are the most critical of our nation "because their sensitivity and their concern for justice, which must motivate any true artist, makes him aware that our Nation falls short of its highest potential" (Kennedy, 1963). He publicly addresses the need to have criticism for the nation through arts.

Five minutes in, Kennedy nears the end of his speech leaving the audience with hoping the U.S. would look to artistic achievement alongside the more material achievements in commerce and statesmanship, he "I look forward to an America which will steadily raise the standards of artistic accomplishment" (Kennedy, 1963). The speech did not just serve as a eulogy for what had been, and who Robert Frost had been, but a public proclamation for the future, the

President letting a country know that artistic achievement is essential for the nation and a true matter of its character. It belongs next to the traditional measures of a nation, and holds steadfast.

His Amherst speech is significant amidst his other speeches rhetorically, but also serving as an accidental capstone to one of his greatest national legacies. This speech, for the last time, codified all the structure Kennedy and his advisers had been building. The galas, the inaugural point, the advisory councils, the beginning of fundraising for a project that would eventually become the Kennedy Center in D.C. This national attachment becomes permanent, and inherited. When campaigns later use celebrities, they are borrowing cultural capital that Kennedy formally elevated here. He believed their meaning belonged in public life, and at Amherst, he just happened to say it the last time.

### ***Intellectual and Cultural Achievement***

Though at some point declaring to the all New York Times that he should not think of a Secretary of Culture, or the government specifically directing an “order that culture exist” out of fear, fear of enforcing conformity, making the US like the communists, Kennedy still had a place for this cultural achievement in mind (Schonberg, 1960). He does add that the encouragement of arts is a “function of government” and that the government should provide the setting in which culture can exist and thrive, and its: prerequisites, freedom, education, and intellectual curiosity should be a government provided setting (Schonberg, 1960). He also rather liberally in this article proposes reduced tax burden on artists, many of whom he understands are living on smaller incomes to create their best work, and are “plundered by the treasury” (Schonberg, 1960). Kennedy, before he is in office, hopes to see America with more culture, but is not as clear as to how.

Following his campaign, with various messages about arts and artists, Kennedy lived up to these campaign efforts, and had made and attempted to follow through with the promise of reinvigorating America, selecting the arts as one means to raise the level of American civilization (103). Kennedy, or between him and his advisors, one of them notably, Arthur Schlesinger Jr., two-time Pulitzer winner and the later author of *A Thousand Days*, had combined efforts to make Arts a national priority. Though much of it was left incomplete - and handed down to Johnson following Kennedy's assassination. Kennedy pushed the idea of intellectual and cultural achievement - specifically through the arts at an unprecedented level. Schlesinger argues very early on, in a new call for “qualitative liberalism” part of which includes the call for improving the public domain that cultural activities need to be included. In the eyes of Kennedy and his people, as spoken about within his campaign, within the bounds of the cold war, American excellence was the domestic solution to fighting communism. This domestic focus had internal benefits for the nation as well as giving the upper hand to lift the United States foreign image. While it would be incorrect to assume that the whole reason for this is the Cold war, American exceptionalism is indeed at play. A few other factors, including John and Jacqueline’s personal interests and her role as first lady, and as an effort to improve quality of life and counteract the more accepted mundane and commercial values of a post WW2, capitalist society.

The Cold war was an extremely motivating factor for the Kennedy administration in hoping to increase the image of Americans in the Cold war. Though it may be nice to imagine a simple love of culture and love of theatre and the arts is the cause of such an unprecedented increase in domestic support for the arts, it is baked in the idea of American exceptionalism. Kennedy saw arts as a tool, a policy tool to promote cultural superiority in the Cold War. Success and cultural prowess would demonstrate in their success of the American ideas and democracy. It

would prove in one manner, to the other nations, and internally, that America is worth fighting for. These examples of the reason behind the increase of support are shown in a letter from Kennedy to *Musical America* (The oldest American magazine on classical music). Kennedy had a competitive attitude and nature, especially in regards to the Communist tide. He truly considered strength in the Arts as a foreign policy measure, quoted claiming art is “a chief means for proclaiming America's message to the world over the heads of dictators”(Binkiewicz, 199, 6 pg104). This goes further, with him encouraging the increase of and educational international exchange programs, as well as the State Department's cultural exchange programs (eventually signing the Hayes-Fulbright act in 1961, whose goal is to increase mutual educational and cultural exchange) to *educate* citizens of communist countries. JFK wanted everyone to be able to come to the US and see for themselves and compare it to what they had been told. Internally, great art is something that is something anyone, from a housewife, to politician, dissenters and artis could rally behind. The soft power of cultural capital is remarkable and important to Kennedy, and that need for American excellence, and exceptionalism in the cold war – supported the spur of cultural and artistic innovation in the United States.

Jacqueline and John also had personal vested interests in the Arts. Kennedy was that of a young man who attended Choate, elite private boarding school in New England, Princeton and Harvard. Enjoying literature and poetry, ballet, and operas, and popular and Irish music. He claims not to have been sophisticated in tastes however, when looking between him and Nixon, Kennedy had the ability to belabor. Nixon mentioned *Oklahoma!*, and *Swan Lake* as his music as opposed to Kennedy's choices Ravel's *La Valse*, Debussy's *Afternoon of a faun* among other perhaps unsophisticated choices. His answer reveals knowledge, or as is significantly mentioned, good campaigning and public relation training as opposed to artistic intelligence. Jacqueline was

the artist of the house, the White House. We can explore her greater influence on art in the White house later, as well as JFK's enjoyment of musicals in discussion about Camelot. John enjoyed the more traditional, the historical while Jackie enjoyed the fine arts and more modern enjoyments of music.

Increasing quality of life was another pillar of choice to boost the arts in the Kennedy Administration. Intellectuals at the time argued that Americans in a post WW2- capitalist society were becoming soft. In *The Lonely Crowd* David Riesman argues that American consumption outweighed production (David, 1950). Moving to the suburbs, having more free time in a mass-produced world devoted to leisure. Note, also, increasing conformity, which as was mentioned before was an increasing risk and a communist threat. Americans were becoming hollow, shells of what an American once was, with a new consumer culture (David, 1950). One of Kennedy's advisors John Kenneth Galbraith found economic discrepancy with the same idea, while GDP was increasing, and economic abundance was too, quality of life was going down (Binkiewicz, 1996). He painted the picture “ air-conditioned, power-steered and power-braked automobiles” to take drives through cities that [were] “badly paved, made hideous by litter, blighted by buildings, billboards,” (John Kenneth, 1958, pg 4.. This created a weakened lack of intellect, thought and true cultural goals he hoped to stop the “ potentially destructive downward spiral of American culture”. He wished the state would get involved investing in the men and active education of them rather than the military, knowing their creativity and intelligence were more important for the U.S. 's future (Binkiewicz, 1996, ph 107). Kennedy was often looking to Galbraith for economic consulting, having a real impact on the choices of the president. Increasing efforts in education and the arts, as an attempt to nationally stimulate the American mind, to fight the mundane commodity based culture, avoid conformity (communist

culture) and truly demonstrated the success of American democracy as a valid fight against communism both domestically and internationally (Binkiewicz, 1996).

Kennedy also, though through his advisors, began choices that would eventually produce the National Endowment for the Arts (NEA) and the National Endowment for the Humanities (NEH). In 1962, Kennedy appointed August Heckscher II, a lecturer and writer on politics, the arts, and public affairs as a Special Consultant on the Arts (Phifer, 2017). Heckscher would argue that the “government should plan with aesthetic consideration” (Phifer, 2017). Heckscher submits a report before he resigns in 1963, “The Arts and the National Government,” calling for an arts advisory council among other improvements to the American support of the arts (Phifer, 2017). Kennedy would follow through with some of these suggestions in 1963, six months before his assassination, Kennedy signed Executive Order 11112 , to establish an arts advisory committee (Establishing the President’s Advisory Council on the Arts, 1963). Past his time in office, this first official step led the way for another National Council on the Arts was established in 1964, the NEA and NEH was established by Congress and Lyndon B Johnson in 1965 (Phifer, 2017). Kennedy's actions raised the bar for artists in the US and around the world.

### ***Hickory Hill***

Hickory Hill was purchased after the death of Supreme Court Justice Robert Jackson in 1941. Justice Jackson lived in this house while dealing with some of the nation's most important cases. While in residence, Jackson served as the Chief Prosecutor for the U.S. during the Nuremberg trials, defending free speech in schools in *West Virginia State Board of Education v. Barnette* (1943), the case in which saluting the flag, and pledging allegiance, is no longer compulsory as a violation of the first amendment. In 1954, while supporting *Brown vs Board of Education* he suffered a heart attack, leading to his wife selling the 1870s property to

Massachusetts newest junior senator, John F. Kennedy. It was here, where Kennedy – and a suspected ghostwriter, Ted Sorensen – wrote his Pulitzer award winning –though under dubious circumstances– book, *Profiles in Courage* (1956). This book exemplifies Kennedy's interest in intelligence, history, and excellence.

The house itself is nothing less than historic. First built-in 1812, burnt down and rebuilt in 1870s (and perhaps again) by Quaker carpenter and farmer, Mr. Walters, an abolitionist, who refused to fight in the civil war, passing hands to a dentist, then his neighbor, and car salesman, and eventually Justice Jackson (Blitz, 2018). The interior of the house finds itself an equal raconteur. Before Ethel Kennedy (Robert's Wife) sold the house, one could find a catalog equal in strength as any presidential library, handwritten paper from Lincoln, letters from former presidents Jefferson, Washington, and Jackson (Joan, 2011). The house is filled with other antiques, paintings, books and other historical furnishings, formal at first glance - the house once filled with people, tells a very different story.

The Kennedy's move out to Georgetown, and sell the estate to their parents, who then rent it out to John's brother, Robert F. Kennedy (Senior). This family, this legacy came to be entrenched at Hickory Hill (Blitz, 2018). RFK's hickory hill felt a lot like the JFK white house, full of arts, but with even more life and joy. With 11 children, farm animals, and always full of guests, the house was buzzing with vigor. The house, often used for meetings with colleagues, friends, dignitaries, scientists, entertainers, academics, athletes, and politicians in steady debate and questioning (Blitz, 2018). The house was a house of wisdom, RFK ("Bobby") would encourage Arthur Schlesinger (one of JFKs advisors) to hold intellectual lectures and seminars over dinner parties, following the same questioning (Blitz, 2018). These seminar parties took off within Washington society, often being recreated by others (Blitz, 2018). The intellectualism at

Hickory Hill is within the Kennedy tradition, carried even in the privatest of settings. This New York Senator brought a causal, and joyful, even celebratory air to excellence in intelligence, but what about the arts?

As rambunctious as the children, the pets, and the intellectuals were – The (Robert F) Kennedy’s at hickory hill excelled at one other thing: Parties. State dinners, and the more formal musicians, artists, and galas were held at the White House in the Kennedy administration -- Hickory Hill was the place to party. Bobby and Ethel Kennedy were known for their extravagant parties with an even more extravagant guest list. On any given party, one could find guests from all high political society, singing, dancing and sipping drinks (TIME, 1962). You could see Harry Belafonte teaching guests to dance, and the same guests jumping in the pool (or being pushed in by Ethel) and changing into borrowed clothes from the hosts. In conversation with David Eisenhower (grandson of President Eisenhower), he says the house was always lively, full of musicians and artistic contemporaries. The house was a party, at all times whether with 300 guests of traditionally high honor, or eleven children running about, playing competitive sports.

Hickory Hill in function and theory is an important place in the cannon Kennedy myth (McCann & Mollan, 2022). McCann and Mollan, argue, rather serendipitously than within the physical bounds of remembrance and locations, Kennedy's leadership was cultivated and promoted with an emphasis on leadership’s cultural and aesthetic aspects (2022). Hickory Hill, rather than Hyannis Port, served as a symbolic place of the New Frontier. Hickory Hill exemplified the arguments about the care and taste for arts and culture in the Kennedy legacy.

## *Camelot*

JFK's "Camelot" is a Kennedy's Camelot, is a reference to multiple Camelots. Three, to be precise. The first instance of Camelot came from Jacqueline, in the LIFE article, "For President Kennedy: An Epilogue". This coined her coin her eternal quote-

*““Don't let it be forgot, that once there was a spot, for one brief shining moment that was known as Camelot” – and it will never be that way again.”*

Thus began the Arthurian legacy attached to President Kennedy. The first half of this is a quote from a song called "Finale Ultimo" from the 1960 Broadway Musical, *Camelot* with Music by Frederick Loewe, and Book and Lyrics by Alan Jay Lerner. The last line of the show, highlighting the temporary existence of the shining night, the perfect court and hope for the future, taken by the evil Mordred. The end of Camelot, the musical, is the similar end to T.H. White's *The Once and Future King*, full of tragedy, with hope for the future, as there was a shining moment, the fact that there was, may mean there will be again. Jackie says it will never be that way again, not for her. With the hope that the legacy will be remembered, the memory carried on.

This Camelot, is the musical, the place, and the reference to Kennedy's reign. Camelot is the kingdom of Arthur, and is a most evident, public example of the excellence and joy that the democratic party began to call their traits. Camelot, as an award winning musical, exemplary of the arts and joy, and Camelot as a classic Arthurian tale, is tell of excellence and academia. These two themes, Joy and Excellence are what drives the party away from its Southern Democratic populist roots, still exemplified by Lyndon B. Johnson following Kennedy's death. Camelot, is the inciting incident to the crafted legacy following JFK's martyrdom.

## Celebrity and Campaigns

In the 2024 Presidential Campaign there was a noticeable uptick in the use of celebrities than the previous years. Celebrity involvement, or in some preservatives, interference has been around for over a hundred years, the first known celebrity endorsement came in 1920, when American Jazz star, Al Jolson endorsed Warren Harding for President- this unlike many later endorsements, rather than being, a political, it served more so as an advertisement with Jolson being approached by an ad agency to contribute, it was paid (Harvey, 2025) . For the years leading up to JFK's reign, the majority of celebrities, actors, singers, athletes weren't endorsing or supporting (Harvey, 2025) Morality clauses in contracts kept them from speaking out in any way, the few exceptions being Babe Ruth and Frank Sinatra, whose stardom was uncanceled by any major executives. (Gordemer, 2024) As time has gone forward, morality clauses had lost their grip and the social and political landscape opened to make space for the possibility and eventual necessity of celebrity involvement in campaigns. The Kennedy administration served as an inflection point, inviting artists, musicians, and celebrities both into the White House and onto the national stage. Kennedy didn't just invite celebrities in, he gave them a national stage and a political legitimacy that made their cultural meaning available to campaigns that followed. These artists began to retain political cultural capital and the ability to use it. Eventually, campaigns realized they could use it more than they were, going from endorsements to fundraising to straight up campaign trail partners, a progression most visible in the campaigns of the Clintons, Obama, and eventually Harris

### *The Clinton's*

The Clintons, both Bill and Hillary, used celebrities extensively in their presidential campaigns. In Hillary's presidential campaign, she used Bill as a surrogate too. The two of them used celebrities not just as partners or endorsees, but for financial structure. Each candidate respectively used these celebrities for money, using fame as an effort to fundraise money for themselves and the Democratic National Committee (DNC).

In 1996, Bill Clinton spent three days in California, ending with a star-stuffed fundraiser hosted by Tom Hanks. The event included performances by Barbra Streisand, the Eagles, and Maya Angelou, with attendees including Rob Reiner, Richard Dreyfuss, Joan Collins, and Carrie Fisher (CNN, 1996). This single event has ticket prices up to 12,500 per person, raising over 4 million dollars. The event also drew criticism for his ties to Hollywood money (CNN, 1996). This was not the only large scale hollywood fundraiser in his time. Each time a celebrity was mentioned in the news articles, in the pictures surrounding these fundraisers, serves as an uncouted endorsement, with a name being attached to Clinton.

On Hillary's campaign, the stars don't stop. In the 2016 campaign they took a much more modern and involved approach – inherited from Obama – working with celebrities aside from the fundraising (which still continues). The BBC reports “Every concert, every celebrity appearance in the closing days of Mrs Clinton's campaign has a purpose - to court a key portion of the Democratic coalition that powered Barack Obama to two presidential terms.” (Zurcher, 2016) It is not to just garner more attention, not to gain more donations, but to turn out a specific vote. Stars such as Lebron James means something specific, he is a basketball player, a black basketball player, at a rally in Cleveland (Zurcher, 2016). No intent is hidden in these choices, from Jennifer Lopez in Miami, to target Latino voters, James Taylor in New Hampshire to target

the more liberal, older white voters, Katy Perry at a college campus for the young voters (Zurcher, 2016). No choice is accidental, or due to fame and fame only. Each of these people carry a meaning, and when in combination with Clinton, she receives that derived meaning from her fans (Zurcher, 2016). Clinton, still, lost the election to Donald Trump in 2016.

### ***Obama***

Between the two Clintons, a change was happening in the way presidential campaigns used celebrities. Obama's campaign led this change. In his 2008 campaign Hollywood started not just being used for their donations, or their endorsements like the long standing strategy of Bill Clinton (Newton-Small, 2008). Obama brought celebrities out of pure endorsements and fundraising into a surrogate style campaign, getting out and doing something (Newton-Small, 2008). This shifted celebrity politics from symbolic endorsement toward active surrogate organizing, a strategy Hillary Clinton would later follow in 2016.

### ***Harris***

The 2024 presidential election is an excellent example of all these themes, and their continuation into a celebrity-focused program being run through the Harris-Walz, formerly Biden-Harris, campaign. A list linked here expands on the sheer quantity and star-power of each and every celebrity. The TIME article makes a bit of a distinction, not merely endorsements but people "hitting the trail," on the road, and campaigning with and for a candidate, the almost non-passive format of endorsement. This distinction matters because the 2024 campaign was not only collecting celebrity support. It was sending celebrities into campaign spaces, college campuses, rallies, offices, and battleground events where their presence was an active effort and

a relatively newer form of campaigning. Political surrogates have been around, but in the last 20 years, there has been a sharp increase of celebrity surrogates.

These interactions, endorsements, and surrogates, were not accidental. In campaign headquarters across the country, or at least in Pennsylvania, campaign staffers were hired to connect with creators and celebrities across the battleground states. The Digital Department, at least in Philadelphia, was the lead for this. As the team worked with people to create endorsements and digital surrogates, celebrities, and creators came into events or offices to make content, as seen in the [Instagram Reel](#) featuring Eva Chen, a journalist-author-mom blogger and a slightly dismayed campaign intern better known as the author of this thesis (2024).

In an anonymous interview with a campaign staffer, referred to as “RJ” from here on out, RJ gave a first-person account of the efforts to use social media by the Democratic Party in 2024. RJ worked on a battleground influencer program. At first, this program was only in one state, then brought across the nation by the Biden-Harris Delaware HQ. RJ described the ways they were meant to use influence on the campaign: inviting creators to events with surrogates, in hopes they would post about them; checking in with influencers they found in the area who they thought would be a good fit, seeing if they were interested in partnering with the campaign; establishing relationships with them; and using their interests to choose which events, rallies, or speakers to attend.

Despite Republican speculation, most of these content creators were not being paid. They were given opportunities to attend events, all the information and resources to post if they wanted to, but they were not contractual. Later in the campaign, there were a few paid fellows in very small specific regions, i.e. North Philadelphia, where there were creators who partnered

with the campaign to do a voter education series rather than pro-Harris content. The non-payment sets it apart from traditional campaign media, even apart from other social content, like “Harris HQ” posts or paid for social media advertising.

To RJ, micro-influencers serve as a platform for more specific communities, just as Kennedy had done in an earlier form with his Spanish-speaking commercials. People see community-specific information, localized attention from a candidate, and information from people they trust who are not part of any larger media network. People like people like them, so followers are more likely to be targeted by demographic or with similar interests rather than whatever a campaign chooses. This displays a more organic form of meaning transfer. The celebrity brings recognition and cultural value. The influencer brings community trust, demographic closeness, or a parasocial relationship. Those meanings, both initially applied by the view, now are being applied to the Harris-Walz campaign and in turn seeing the Harris-Walz campaign with the value and meaning they have assigned to the celebrity and the influencer. A viewer is not just seeing campaign content; they are seeing the campaign through people who already mean something to them.

When asked whether these micro-influencer strategies did anything, RJ had a lot of thoughts. He reiterated a thought held by many: people do not go to TikTok or Instagram to get their news. People go in there for entertainment, but most of the time news is on there, and you watch what there is. You unintentionally see so many suggestions and news on your feed that it is almost impossible to make an impact with one singular video from a small creator.

Knowing, and discussing later, the increased recall of celebrities, events where a small influencer a viewer may engage with, or even have a parasocial relationship with, appears with a

celebrity may be more memorable. The influencer might share traits with the viewer, and the celebrity might bring broader recognition. The post is much likelier to be remembered due to the celebrity involvement, and due to both the influencer and the celebrity being attached to a Harris for President post. Without these celebrities attached, it is a numbers game. With short-form content, it requires much more volume to make a message stick, for it to be accepted.

This, RJ thinks, may have been a fault of the Harris campaign strategy: overinvesting in short-form content. The first reason for this was, as explained above, needing a huge quantity of videos to reach a page before a message sticks. The second is an inherent disadvantage to Democratic short-form media: the algorithm and those who own it. X, Meta, and, with supervision, TikTok, are not built to cater to left-leaning political content. On X, f.k.a. Twitter, the algorithm, though largely elusive, seems to push Musk's content and content he might share or like further to the top. At the time of the campaign, he had a pro-Trump stance.

TikTok had been accused of, and as of May 6, had been found to have, a Republican bias algorithm (Ibrahim et al., 2026). The recent study found that Republican-seeded accounts got more content that matched their political side than Democratic-seeded accounts did. Republican accounts received about 11.5% more co-partisan content, content aligned with the side they had been trained on, Republican (Ibrahim et al., 2026). Democratic accounts received about 7.5% more cross-partisan content, meaning content from or against the other side, anti-Democratic or Republican (Ibrahim et al., 2026). Much of the cross-partisan content shown to Democratic accounts was anti-Democratic material (Ibrahim et al., 2026).

The other failings are attributed to the success of the Republican media campaign, which will be discussed later. RJ does think that there was some success within the program across

battleground states. He described the videos as “seeds” that would hopefully plant an idea in someone’s head, and get them talking, reposting, commenting, or making their own content as a form of more organic circulation than a traditional ad campaign.

His account shows a few things about the 2024 election. Events and targets with celebrities and influencers became more built out, starting for the first time in Pennsylvania and reaching across the nation as part of an official campaign strategy, something whose seed was planted 64 years prior. These over 200 micro-influencers brought the campaign closer to people, closer to their demographics, and closer to home, helping target specific physical areas and interests. However, limiting factors, such as retention, general repetition needed to gain retention, and more online capital from the right, made the use of them less effective.

The point is not that celebrity surrogates or micro-influencers single-handedly changed votes. The point is that the Harris-Walz campaign treated celebrities and creators as part of the machinery of political meaning. Their value was not just that they could repeat campaign information. Their value was that they could make the campaign feel culturally present, socially specific, and attached to people voters already recognized or trusted.

### ***Republican vs Democratic Culture***

The Republican and Democratic party and culture have differences when it comes to social media and celebrity culture. In social media, RJ's insights give us some internal views as to how they differ, other than the aforementioned ownership and influence on media landscapes. RJ believes that due to the republican media landscape, with more ultra conservative talk shows, podcasts and increased infrastructure. This infrastructure has been around and online for longer and receives much more direct investment from PAC's and Super PAC's. Some literature

supports the republican theory with the more established media channels. Grossmann and Hopkins help explain this Republican media environment, where the message is more collective and voters often look to a few trusted conservative figures as leaders of thought (2016).

As far as actual content on social media goes, RJ believes in a strict difference in strategy. Right-wing creators were often better at rage bait, virality, and using misinformation or disinformation to gain attention, while Democratic influencers tended to be more informational or even hesitant to fully support the party. This support hesitancy had roots in the democratic canon. Grossmann and Hopkins (2016) show a connection of this disunity all the way back to the New Deal coalition, when rather than gathering around a central ideology, an ideologically varied grouping of people gathered around practical, concrete, economic concerns. The Democratic party rallied, and has continued to organize around a laundry list of goals rather than a central ideology and shared vision. Due to this, the number of self-identified liberals dropped by nearly a quarter between 1963 and 1967 alone, being representative of the difficulties of maintaining a dissimilar ideological voter bloc (Grossman and Hopkins, 2016). Due to this lack of cohesion the coalition looked to charismatic individuals to represent a majority, which any voter bloc may do when lacking an ideological norm. This idea directly connects to Wendy Brown's thoughts on neoliberalism in her book, *Undoing the Demos: Neoliberalism's Stealth Revolution*, which argues that the glamorization of individual politics has degraded the capacity for collective struggle, further pushing Democratic messaging toward individual voices rather than movement-based organizing — in turn allowing celebrities to become a focal point for these individual campaigns (2015). On the other hand, within republican ideological theory they benefit from ideological consistency: an environment built around a few trusted thought leaders delivering a collective conservative message, making their infrastructure more resilient and their

base – anchored by media figures like Ben Shapiro, Tucker Carlson, and more recently Nick Fuentes – less dependent on celebrity influence for political direction.

### *Celebrities Status*

The original term “celebrity” is to be celebrated, or the state of being crowded, at its deepest linguistic roots. Current accounts of what it means to be a celebrity vary, and there are different arguments as to where is talent, skill, excellence or the mere understanding of being known (fame), and questions on what makes a celebrity. While fame, asks whether a person is known or not, and there are famous people sans celebrity, like any given emperor in Japan ( Friedman 1999, 28) but are not a “celebrity”. Older arguments state a celebrity is “a person who is known for his wellknownness” (Boorstin 1962, 57 ). Now, a celebrity may not need, or have talent, as they may have in the past, as let's say, the young strapping grandson of a martyred President like John Bouvier Kennedy Schlossberg better known as Jack Schlossberg who before his talent and skills (a JD and MBA) was known (fame) simply for who he was related to, and celebrated due to that (celebrity). Traditionally, before the time of social media, exiting the age of talkies, and into television and movies and live performances- celebrity almost wholeheartedly requires talent, skill and recognition of that skill. This seems to forget the almost necessity of attractiveness, a value thought about often looking at entertainment, specifically actors.

The defining difference between fame and celebrity is fans, people looking to them, to influence or capture attention, but just be known. A celebrity must have an externality attached to their value that is a benefit from being known they have their reason for being famous, but there must be something beyond that, fans who care and listen. An explanation for this, while being explained later though mean transfer has a need for a celebrity, rather than just a

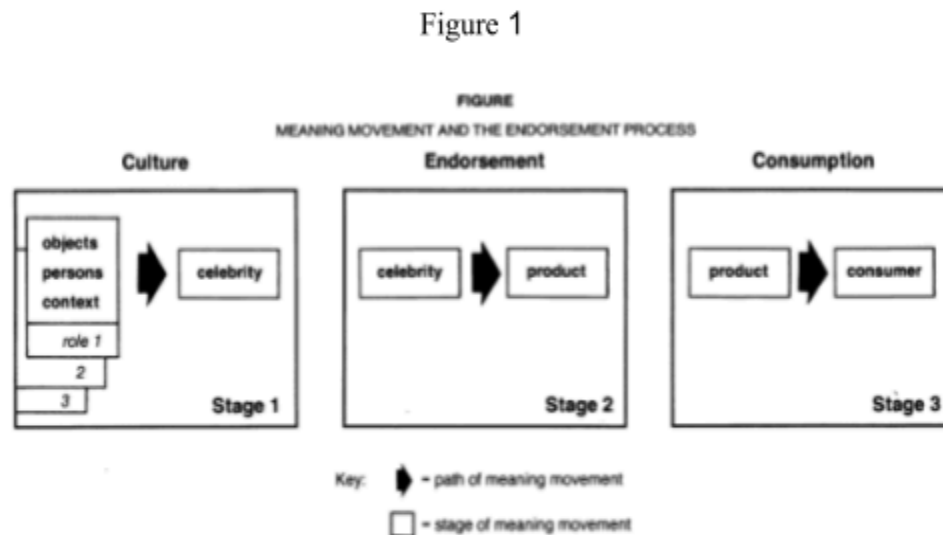
famous person, to have some sort of meaning ascribed to them by the general public (or their fans) this meaning can help develop a parasocial relationship – a relationship between a fan, and a celebrity in which the fan has had no meaningful interaction, relationship or event contact with a celebrity, yet has the feeling of a built out relationship due to their following and pierced closeness of said celebrity – which makes any external move outside of a celebrities main traits, more impactful.

The general understanding of political messaging had been elaborated on in Zaller's *The Nature and Origins of Mass Opinion* following the RAS model (Receive, Accept, Sample) (1992). This model follows four axioms. 1) Reception - being the more a person is engaged with an issue, the more likely they are to comprehend messaging surrounding the issue. 2) Resistance – people tend to resist messaging based on predisposition, but also need some predisposition to connect a message to the predisposition. 3) Accessibility – the more a message has been thought about, the more likely it is to come to mind quickly. 4) Response – people answer with the most accessible information they have on hand (Zaller, 1992). Using what is known about reception in messaging, any of other research on political messaging and celebrity endorsements become clearer.

### ***Meaning Transfer***

The second, and most valuable method of understanding how the theoretical endorsement process works is through the idea of meaning transfer. Developed by Grant McCracken, the model of meaning transfer seeks to explain how meanings pass from a celebrity, to a product, and

from the product back to the consumer as explained in the following figure (1989).



McCracken, G. (1989). Who is the Celebrity Endorser?  
Cultural Foundations of the Endorsement Process. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 16(3), 310–321.

Unlike some other understandings about celebrity influences, about attractiveness (is this person likable, or familiar) or via credibility (is this person trustworthy or an expert), both seen in Petty and Cacioppo's Elaboration Likelihood Model, explained later, which explains how much a celebrity can influence your decisions. McCracken asks why, and holds the idea that the persuasiveness of the celebrity has everything to do with who the celebrity is (1989). This may seem pedantic and strikingly obvious, of course it would have to do with who the celebrity is. Without that distinction, relying solely on attractiveness and credibility, any sufficiently likable and trusted celebrity should theoretically work for any product (McCracken, 1989). John Houseman should have been as effective for McDonald's as he was for Smith Barney (McCracken, 1989). The only exception would be a celebrity with domain-specific expertise, say, a Bill Nye endorsing science education, where credibility is tied to a particular

field. But outside of that narrow case, the source models offer no explanation for why some pairings work and others fail. The meaning transfer process aims to explain that disconnect.

As depicted in Figure 1., the meaning transfer process happens in three stages. The first, Stage 1, is an accumulation of meaning – through everything that happens to a celebrity in their life that might be known enough to the public, their career, their roles, their public life and all their scandals and good deeds. Think Steve Buscemi, known for being a bit of an oddball in his roles and in real life, or Ye (f.k.a. Kanye West) for having various mood changes and problematic outbursts, or Samuel L. Jackson for playing an intense authority figure with a distinctive voice. All of these collected meanings, and experiences mean something. These meanings are assigned by a person, by the consumer, and generally the public's understanding of a celebrity. This brings to Stage 2 in the model, where in an endorsement, or in this case, a product but for campaigns, a candidate, transfers some of that gained meaning to the product (whether intentional or not)(McCracken, 1989). Stage 3 returns the meaning back to the consumer, from the product– now associating the new assigned meaning (and celebrity) with the product(McCracken, 1989).

While mismatches seem to kill an endorsement, matches would theoretically do better, think back to Hillary Clinton's 2016 campaign and the people she chooses. LeBron James in Cleveland, Jennifer Lopez in Miami, and in Harris' campaign Beyonce's "Freedom". Campaign strategy selects people who have stage 1 meanings that would draw in a greater audience and those sympathetic and aligning with the celebrity and hope that when that meaning is transferred, their fans, attention, and meaning goes to the candidate, garnering another vote or convincing a person to act.

McCracken lays out and describes stage one as something accumulated through public understanding performance and during the life of a celebrity (1989). I propose a further sentiment attached to McCracken's understanding. Attaching a cultural and national memory and understanding to Stage 1. This years long accumulated memory is where John F. Kennedy's actions in the 60s, giving arts a national value and being lifted up by policy and memos and assigning that collected meaning generally to celebrities we see as talented and worth the uplifting. Kennedy institutionalized a condition where celebrities have political value in the United States. This applies specifically to celebrities whose fame is rooted in talent and cultural achievement, not those famous purely for visibility, whose Stage 1 meanings carry little political transferability. It took the ability to share their meaning over social media and to more specific populations in campaigns to have a widespread use (2008 and afterward). In doing so, Kennedy established a reverse meaning structure: where talent and artistic excellence could now support state affairs, not just reflect them. His campaign became a template, and Democratic campaigns since have broadened and expanded what he began.

### ***Endorsements and Behavior***

Endorsements are a staple in American life – from Micheal Cera's Cerave Campaign, to Oprah's Book Club to Ronald Reagan promoting cigarettes to Doris Day for international harvesters. Celebrity endorsements have been used to impact consumer behavior since messages could be spread far and wide, whether pictures in print, or recognizable voice over the airwaves. Much more research lies in marketing, on a consumer based approach rather than a voter based approach - however in the few studies between common overlaps are found in results - bringing the assumption that for most studies, the information would apply to a voting thought process not an actual vote.

The research has found that celebrity endorsements have a limited direct impact on first person voter behavior. Endorsements may attract attention and influence some opinions, but they do not directly translate to votes as campaigns might hope. Veer, Becirovic, and Martin find that while celebrity endorsements attract attention, they do not inherently increase voter intention. Though their study was conducted in the UK, its findings likely apply elsewhere (Veer et al., 2010). Two studies found that though in some cases, celebrities may seem more trustworthy than politicians or non-celebrity influences, and family and friends are more likely to be trusted as political influence overall (O'Regan, 2014). When looking at the party split, Republicans rely more on family for voting decisions; celebrity endorsements have limited overall impact but are viewed slightly more favorably by Democrats (Wood & Herbst, 2007). Even given all this, attitudes toward political figures and public policy are not fixed in childhood and remain open to influence, so almost nothing is a lost cause, and most efforts could have at least minimal impact (Tesler, 2015).

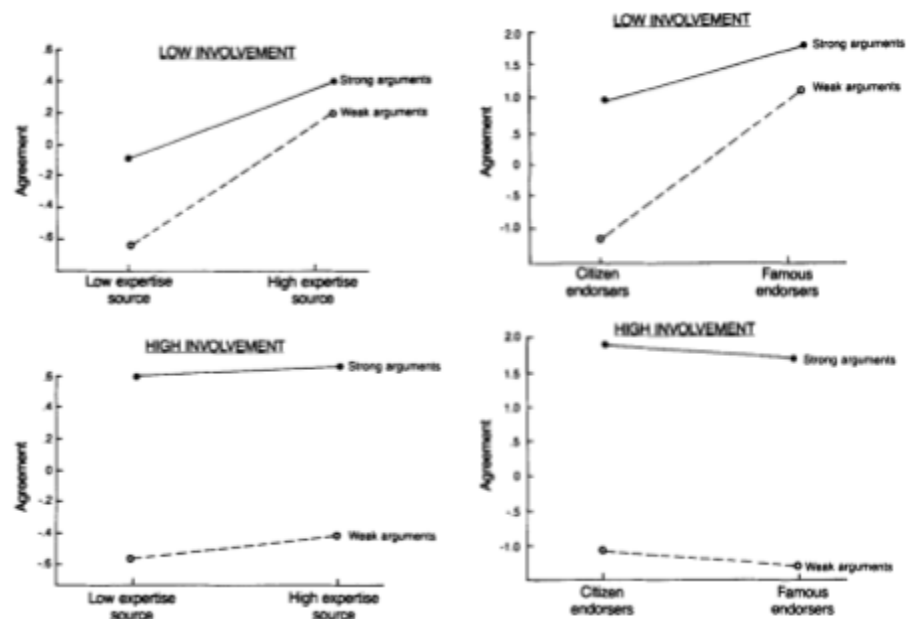
Studies, in general, have found it hard to prove effectiveness (or ineffectiveness) of endorsements on direct votes in campaigns (Stratmann 2005). When attempting to measure, often the results are skewed by the endorsee's and the voter's inherent political leaning. Political preferences of a celebrity you would respect and listen to, and your own are likely correlated. A further argument, however, is that one is not asking someone to switch parties, and vote for a new candidate, but rather mobilize and turn out a vote. Looking into that, there are measurable and known influences on voting choices, thought and habits, even if not direct endorsement-to-vote output .

As far as celebrity endorsements, in the young adult age range (18-24) in 2007, 40% of those voters reported having some influence from celebrity endorsements, whereas only 15% of

older adults did (Wood & Herbst, 2007). More generally, the same study found overall respondents were somewhat positive about celebrities using their voice to enforce voter turnout, but less so about specific candidates (Wood & Herbst, 2007). It's also assumed celebrities' built-in platforms and attention may give them more influence than experimental studies capture. With that attention, and this will come back up later, celebrity attachment increases message recall and brand recognition (Atkinson & DeWitt, 2016)

There was also a visible manner in which political engagement moderates endorsement effects. In O'Regan's case, there was a statistically significant difference in AAPI and Hispanic (2014). This comes with the theory that “first-generation college students may not consider their parents as politically knowledgeable due to their parents' lack of a college education” (O'Regan, 2014). Politically disengaged (low-salience) voters are more susceptible to celebrity influence, while highly engaged (high-salience) voters are less affected (Veer et al., 2010). Celebrity endorsements are used as shortcuts for low-information voters (Veer et al., 2010). In the same manner, but socially rather than salience, for people with weaker political socialization parasocial relationships were more likely to lead fans to use celebrities as cues for beliefs (Gunter, 2014).

As well as salience, proximity played an important role in the effect of persuasion. Using Petty & Cacioppo's “Elaboration Likelihood Model of Persuasion” (ELM), it's understood that there are two routes to processing information and persuasion: the central (analytic, systematic, cognitively demanding), Peripheral (heuristic, superficial, cognitively undemanding) routes (1986). Celebrity endorsements are more effective when looking at the peripheral route.



(John T. Cacioppo & Richard E. Petty, 1986)

Following what we know about salience, in both situations, in ELM when involvement (personal relevance) was lower external factors had a stronger effect. In terms of source credibility, it matters significantly more when personal impact is less at stake, in the researcher's case, being a product available in your area vs unavailable to you but to others. As far as celebrity endorsements run – when low involvement is the case, famous endorsements matter significantly whether the argument is weak or strong and when it is personally relevant – famous sources may actually have a negative effect. What this study doesn't do, is combine the two, which would be helpful when looking at campaigning. Going back to the idea of meaning transfer, a celebrity could be famous, but also have relatively high credibility in actions or in meaning.

Figure 2

Where it's harder to see direct effects in voting behavior; celebrity endorsements in products are measurable (Agrawal & Kamakura, 1995). Showing both, Garthwaite and Moore give us the most clear case of celebrity endorsement being an effective tool in converting, or turning out votes lies in President Obama's primary campaign (2013). Oprah, long-known for her talk show, and product endorsements, had a track record of endorsement, directly linked to uptick in purchases of books when her book club with *Anna Karenina* an already classic raising 5400% in sales and Sidney Poitier's memoir *The Measure of a Man* going from less than a thousand sales three months prior to the book club, to 866,000 sales in the three months following, a 12800% increase. It is no doubt that Oprah is a major influence on her watchers and those readers. The question asked in the study is whether she had a true effect on elections. Though various studies have had their struggles proving a direct celebrity-to-vote output, Garthwaite and Moore find that with no prior connection to Obama, or his previous campaigns, no significant relationship to Oprah Magazine and already democratic vote shares, negative relationships with other, similar magazines –that Oprah's endorsement garnered 1,015,559 votes for Obama in his primary campaign. The research also suspects that her endorsement turned out 2,196,300 voters in the primary campaign overall. Though this does not apply to primary campaigns, and seems to go against further research - the information aligns well with what is known about consumer behavior- this is just a real life example played out in these circumstances, even when more controlled for background demographics and understanding - the primaries are a place generally with lower political salience and therefore more susceptible to influence.

### *Social Media and Celebrity Influence*

Social media is a tool for communication, and political communication all the same- a place where people are both consumers and producers. A hypothesis in Zelinsky's findings and others was that political content on social media, particularly Twitter, would receive less engagement than entertainment content (2020). However, this was not the case. Political content got either a negligible amount less, or sometimes more interaction (Zilinsky et al., 2020). Similarly it was expected that, like other forms of political media, negative posted content would receive more interaction. It was thought that if it received more interaction, it would be posted more because in traditional media, negative information is more likely to be paid attention to, processed centrally, and subsequently remembered, so It would theoretically benefit to post a smear campaign (Zilinsky et al., 2020) The information was again, not statistically significant to support these hypotheses about interactions or posting, in fact they argue it may be the opposite (Zilinsky et al., 2020). In this more recent research, a question of things in 2016 changed significantly and unexpectedly in regards to social media and content about Donald Trump, who posts a significant amount, both positive and negative . This leads to further questions of the way media and campaigns are run and how they are changing, if the current strategies are effective, or are any strategies effective at all?

The abundance of information on social media manifests in two ways: overwhelming and educational. In Nisbett and DeWalt's paper, social media abundance leads to campaigns thinking they are doing a lot, being cutting edge, and hip but it may not have the impact they intend - social media was seeming like "a glut of political chatter [...], making it hard to cut through the clutter." overwhelming and confusing media consumers ( 2016). Zilinsky et al. argue an opposite approach, they say increased campaign information raises the likelihood that

non-political actors would encounter and engage with political content, increasing their political knowledge and saliency; especially for less active voters. Interestingly if using this with Veer, Becirovic and Martin's study, which argues low-salience voters are more influenced by celebrity endorsements High-salience voters prefer non-celebrity endorsers and focus more on issue-based cues, then the whole thing is circular. A formerly low-salience voter, after spending time on social media, and accidentally consuming political content, might result in a more in-tune participant, who would go from susceptible to celebrity and media influence, to consuming it, and due to that consumption being more salient and less moved by celebrity endorsements (Nisbett and DeWalt, 2016). This might result in a claim that celebrity endorsements may work, but maybe only once.

In the 2024 election, there was a surge of “micro-influencers” (social media content creators with follower counts typically ranging from 10,000 to 100,000) working with the Harris campaign. The over-saturation incited questions about their actual impact. These micro-influencer, (and traditional influencer partnerships with people who may be considered genuinely famous from social media influence) were used both as endorsements, but also surrogates, and other campaign materials on behalf of the Harris campaign. With thousands of ‘boots on the ground’ acting as miniature surrogates, It makes the need to study the impact greater.

### **Celebrity Credibility and Risk**

In any circumstance, entrusting credibility to others carries inherent risks and challenges. The same is seen in celebrity endorsements and surrogacy. The literature shows that not all celebrities are perceived equally; in elections, credibility matters more than fame (Nisbett and

DeWalt, 2016). Celebrities must be seen as knowledgeable to have political influence (Nisbett and DeWalt, 2016; O'Regan, 2014). Congruence between a celebrity and the issue determines effectiveness – like how Eva Longoria was seen as credible on immigration but not on finance (Nisbett and DeWalt, 2016). The opposite is also true, as seen in Sean P. “Diddy” Combs’ *Vote or Die* campaign (a campaign to get youth and minorities voting). Celebrities perceived as lacking credibility, such as Kim Kardashian or Paris Hilton, were less effective in mobilizing students and viewers, who were less inclined to support the movement (Nisbett and DeWalt, 2016)

As previously noted in discussions of Diddy and voting efforts, endorsements carry risk. A candidate cannot always predict a celebrity’s actions, past or future – an issue that makes the inclusion of Sean Combs in Nisbett and DeWalt’s paper on youth voter turnout both unavoidable and uniquely challenging. This makes even referencing him, in tandem with your voter turnout, seem weird, directly showing the risks of celebrity impact on campaigns, they could end up like *Vote or Die*. While mostly seen in Von Sikorski, Knoll and Matthes’ work but also touched on in Devine and Weinschenk’s paper as well, harmful endorsements at the moment, or down the line are likely and all too real (Devine and Weinschenk, 2016; Von Sikorski et al., 2018). A controlled survey found that a celebrity's personal misbehavior can damage an endorsed politician. If the endorsement was politician-initiated, voters held the politician more responsible for the endorser's actions (Von Sikorski et al., 2018). In the case that it happened, and was self initiated he also found that a “denouncing response reinforced the fact that the politician initiated and was in control of the endorsement”, tying them more closely (Von Sikorski et al., 2018). They find that might be beneficial to address scandals, if the endorsement was not politician-initiated (Von Sikorski et al., 2018). Though with this, a difference between pity and anger arose,

pity was a sign of more positive influence, and anger negative in regards to related scandals (Von Sikorski et al., 2018). Divine touches on the risk of Bill Clinton's surrogacy for his wife, Hillary Clinton due to the linkage of his sexual misconduct and policies that were gathering in unpopularity (Devine and Weinschenk, 2016)

### ***Surrogacy vs Endorsement***

Surrogacy, as defined in campaigns, are "individuals who speak on behalf of a candidate or party during an election campaign, representing their views and promoting their platform". Campaign surrogacy began early in the American experiment, and was used from the Gilded Age in the past, until now (Lee, 2016). The premise of campaign surrogacy was to have a candidate's presence as far as possible, because the candidate could only do so much and travel so far. Surrogacy, in the modern day, is still used to help increase exposure and influence voters, particularly among younger or disengaged voters. The idea is that a celebrity or other political figure that someone may enjoy or trust, campaigns for a different politician (called a principal in political campaigns). Surrogacy is different from endorsement. Endorsement is voicing support, and just that, while surrogacy is campaigning for the candidate, by oneself, or in tandem with the principal. Clearly, the use of campaign surrogates was extreme this past election cycle which led to the question of the effectiveness of surrogates, and particularly celebrity surrogates, as there was both a noticeable increase of celebrities in elections, and talk about celebrity surrogacy in elections, at least, admittedly, in my social circles and online space.

### ***Celebrity Surrogacy vs Traditional Figures***

The unstudied intersection of celebrity surrogacy, beyond simple endorsements but distinct from traditional political surrogacy, presents a need to identify key differences. In an

overview of Bill Clinton's surrogacy, Devine finds spouses, former presidents, and political elites often hold more credibility than celebrities (Devine and Weinschenk, 2016). But even with the increase in credibility, Bill's presentation on the campaign trail had a mixed effect, boosting in some occasions and hurting it in others (Devine and Weinschenk, 2016 ). He argues that celebrity surrogates like Beyoncé and Jay-Z may mobilize young voters, but their long-term impact remains unclear.

## **Conclusion**

The question that set this research question off, initially being why to thank any given celebrity for their time. The question I had set out to answer seems to have found its resolution. Lin-Manuel Miranda is thanked for his contribution to the campaign, for the lending of all of those understandings and meanings that have been prescribed to him over his lifetime, a celebrated composer and lyricist, an actor and the modern embodiment of a man fighting for American independence. He comes to a pizza parlor at the edge of University City and West Philadelphia to talk to seventy-some students, the students hear him, yes as Lin-Manuel Miranda, but also as everything he means to popular culture. He is Hamilton telling you to vote, telling you to care. Sixty years prior, there was President Kennedy telling the nation that composers, poets, actors, singers, musicians and artists must and do mean something to the nation. They were given national endorsement, and the Harris campaign was borrowing the meaning from Kennedy.

Before Kennedy, celebrities were few and far between in politics. The occasional helping hand, song or endorsement but nothing on the scale we would see following. Kennedy, as has been explored in this paper, structurally changed an American approach to excellence and arts in

culture. Kennedy raised art to a level of domestic and international importance for the strength and soul of the nation. Kennedy rhetorically supported the arts in his inauguration speech, at one of his last speeches, and with actions throughout the entire duration of his presidency formally like establishing an advisory committee, and informally like hosting artists during state dinners. Kennedy built up this meaningful relationship with the arts, and the nation.

The long term effects of this meaningful relationship can be explained through McCracken's theory of meaning transfer (1989). Meaning accumulates through a celebrity's life, from their roles, skills, public discourse and any other way that might accumulate it. That meaning transfers to a product, or in this case a candidate through endorsement or surrogacy. Once transferred to the product, a consumer (or a voter), the same person who ascribed meaning to the initial endorser, the meaning comes back when looking at the product (or candidate). Kennedy's actions added a national, institutional layer to Stage 1 giving celebrities a politically meaningful position in the United States.

In the 2024 presidential campaign, those understandings were put to use. Whether intentional or not – the concept of meaning transfer was used even in statewide strategy as learned from talking to campaign staffers. The age of the internet has helped them along the way, being able to directly target voters Stage 1 thoughts and interest to connect to celebrities who can bring them to a main candidate. Unfortunately, for the democratic party, they worked against structural and economical challenges through social media and the traditional media landscape.

Through various research discoveries it's come to be understood that there are tools through endorsements and various programs that work with varied effects, and occasionally inverse effects and risks when it comes to celebrity endorsements which Sean Combs

exemplifies well. Endorsements attract attention and can move low-salience voters, but rarely convert or single-handedly turn out a vote. Surrogates still do have inherent value, through the attention economy and through the meaning of their own, via meaning transfer, and when used efficiently can add a final push to an unsure voter, but no guarantee to win an election

The broader takeaway is that celebrities' involvement in campaigns is and has been growing since Kennedy's time to the milestone usage in Harris's 2024 campaign. The lesson is to be keenly aware of thinking less about fame and viewership, and fame but more about the attachment to the 'viewers', the 'consumers', the voters. Campaigns should be looking more to congruence, to learn historically what excellence in arts and culture can do for the United States, and what a celebrity can mean to specific communities. Oprah shows us this can work, Beyonce too. Meaning is the asset to pay attention to. Not numbers. Further research, including experimental survey design testing meaning transfer directly, remains an avenue for future work.

Lin Manuel Miranda was thanked because he was carrying an American national value for Harris, a transfer of cultural meaning that had been carried through Obama, through Clinton through Kennedy, and Robert Frost. Carrying a message that America must uphold its call to enter, and remain in "A golden age of poetry and power" (Frost, 1961).

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